

ATTACHMENT

Brief: Bitless Bridles and Welfare Considerations in Dressage

1. Context

The use of bits in equestrian sport relies on pressure applied within the horse's mouth, an area containing sensitive tissues such as the tongue, bars, and lips.

There is increasing recognition that, in some horses, this may be associated with discomfort, conflict behaviours, and oral injury, as reflected in behavioural and competition-based research. Bitless bridles provide an alternative that removes intra-oral pressure while maintaining rider communication.

2. Welfare Considerations

- Bits act through intra-oral pressure on sensitive structures

Research has identified:

- oral lesions in some sport horses
- behavioural indicators associated with discomfort

Common conflict behaviours include:

- mouth opening
- tongue movements
- head tension or shaking
- Bitless bridles:
 - remove intra-oral pressure
 - allow communication via nose and facial pressure instead
 - are used successfully in training and competition contexts

Welfare principle:

Where a less aversive, effective alternative exists, allowing that option is consistent with a precautionary approach to animal welfare.

3. Practical and Safety Considerations

- Bitless bridles are already permitted in other equestrian disciplines, including show jumping
 - In these contexts, horses are ridden at speed over complex courses
 - This suggests that bitless equipment can be compatible with:
 - effective rider control
 - safe participation
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4. International Context

- The Dutch Equestrian Federation (KNHS) permits bitless dressage at certain levels (up to Small Tour)
 - Bitless riding is increasingly explored internationally in both training and competition
 - This indicates the approach is:
 - established
 - practical
 - not without precedent
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5. Conclusion

Allowing riders the option to use bitless bridles enables equipment choice based on the individual horse and is consistent with a welfare-based approach to training and competition.

6. References

- Cook, W.R. (2014). *Bit-induced pain: a cause of fear, flight, fight and facial neuralgia in the horse*
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- Mellor, D.J. (2020). *Updating animal welfare thinking: moving beyond the Five Freedoms toward a life worth living*
- Dyson, S. et al. (2018). *Behavioural indicators of pain in ridden horses*